OTW Radio launch plan

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Summary

OTW Radio can go live as a 24/7 audio-first internet station on **27 January 2027**, with a soft launch on 11 January, for roughly **$90K to $160K up front and $650K to $1M a year** before royalties. Royalties scale with listening, so they are shown separately in the budget.

- **Audio is the always-on channel.** Music rotation, podcasts and interviews run from cloud automation around the clock.
- **Video is switched on per segment** when an artist wants it, from the same studio and the same AIMC capture used for LiveNation.tv shows.
- **Licensing starts with the US statutory route** (SoundExchange plus the four performing rights organizations), with direct deals for OTW artists to cover live shows, video and anything the statutory license can't.
- **A lean team of about 6 people** runs it, mostly through automation and voice-tracked hosts.

All costs and dates here are planning estimates from general market knowledge, not quotes. Each needs confirming with vendors and legal before commitments.

Format and positioning

OTW Radio is the always-on home for the Ones To Watch roster: new artists, their records, their stories and their stages, on onestowatch.live and wherever people listen.

- **Audio first, video when it earns it.** Every hour has an audio feed. Video appears for live interviews, studio sessions and live shows where the artist opts in, mirroring the VIDEO and AUDIO badges in the LiveNation.tv plan.
- **It feeds the LiveNation.tv pilot.** Live shows captured by AIMC in House of Blues, Fillmore and other rooms can air on OTW Radio the same night, and the station promotes upcoming broadcasts and tickets.
- **Premieres feel live.** Most shows are recorded ahead, stored in AIMC and aired at a fixed time as if live, with no skipping ahead. Real live shows from venues follow the LiveNation.tv rule: no replay unless the artist opts in.

- **Discovery is the hook.** Rotation leans on OTW roster and emerging artists, with enough familiar context around them that a new listener stays.

Programming grid

Every day runs the same five blocks. A weekly feature airs twice, at 10am and again at 3pm, and changes by weekday. Features are scheduled premieres: recorded shows pulled from AIMC and played at a fixed time as if live.

Time (ET, to confirm)	Block	Source
Midnight to 10am	OTW Playlist	AzuraCast rotation from the OTW music library
10am to noon	OTW Weekly Feature, first airing	Premiere from AIMC
Noon to 3pm	Guest Curator Playlist	Playlist picked by a guest artist, with their recorded intros
3pm to 5pm	OTW Weekly Feature, repeat	Same episode as 10am
5pm to midnight	OTW Playlist	AzuraCast rotation

Day	Weekly feature	Content and AIMC source
Monday	OTW Weekly Recap	Produced fresh each week: the week's news, releases and clips
Tuesday	Chef's Choice	Curator picks (format to confirm)
Wednesday	OTW Touring Artists	Artists on the road that week, using their AIMC performances and interviews plus Ticketmaster tour dates
Thursday	GWLMMWLG	Format to confirm
Friday	Artist Interview	One long-form interview. A keyword search finds 63 interview assets in AIMC today

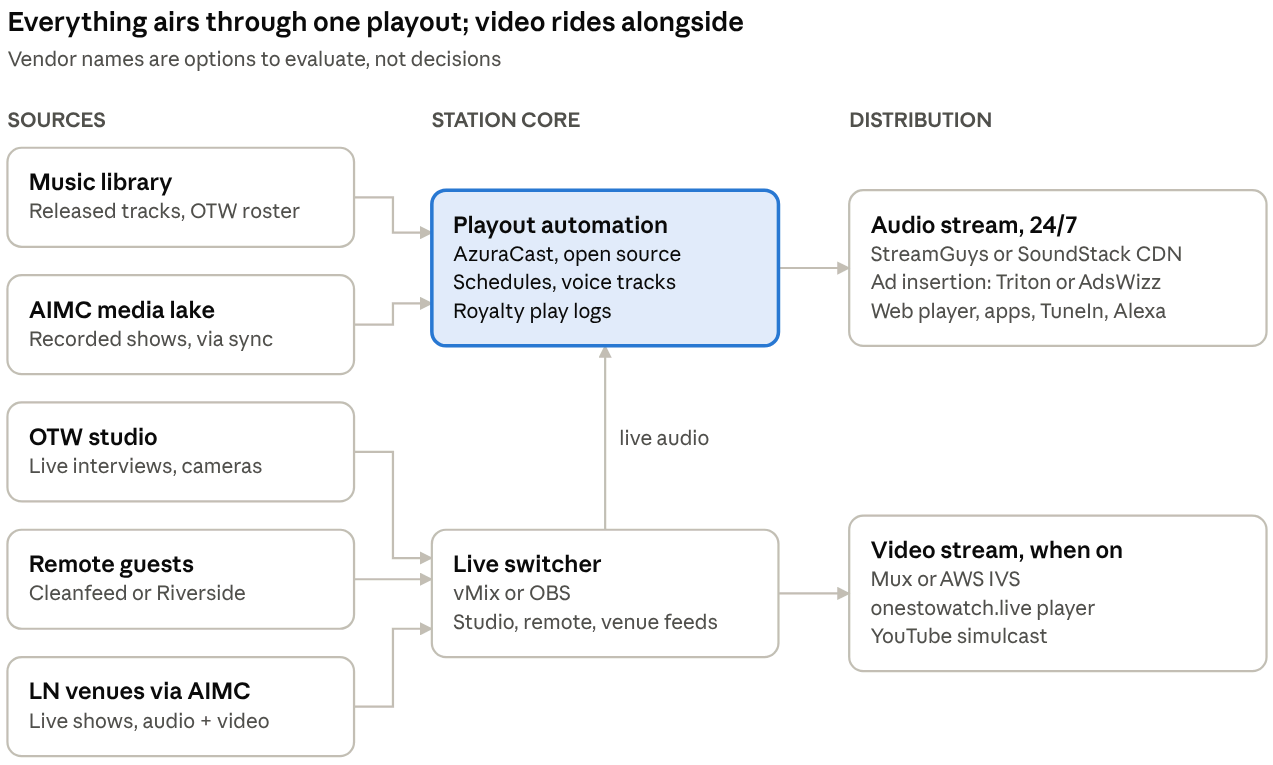
Day	Weekly feature	Content and AIMC source
Saturday (proposed)	Live From the Rooftop	Session performances, an existing OTW series already in AIMC
Sunday (proposed)	Best of the Week	Repeats of the Monday to Friday features

A day is 17 hours of playlist, 3 hours of guest curation and 4 hours of features. Live shows from Live Nation venues can take over the evening playlist on the nights they happen.

The US statutory license limits how much of one artist plays in 3 hours. Guest Curator and Touring Artists hours need a direct license from the featured artist, or a mixed playlist that stays inside the limits.

Tech stack

One cloud playout system runs the 24/7 audio feed, and a live switcher feeds both that playout and a separate video stream whenever an artist turns video on. The engineer can run all of it, and nothing here needs a broadcast tower.



OTW Radio tech stack · sources, station core, distribution

- **Playout: AzuraCast.** It is open source, self-hosted with Docker on one cloud server, and it handles scheduling, live DJ input, the public player and play logs for royalty reporting. Its public player and schedule widgets embed on onestowatch.live, and later onestowatch.com.
- **AIMC is the show warehouse.** AIMC is already an S3 media lake with artist, series and format tags, durations and MP4 proxies. A small sync service pulls each scheduled episode from AIMC, extracts the audio and loads it into AzuraCast as that day's premiere.
- **Video premieres.** AzuraCast is audio only. When a feature has video, the onestowatch.live player plays the AIMC video proxy in step with the schedule, starting at the current point in the show, so it feels live.
- **Live ingest.** Studio and remote interviews go through the switcher into AzuraCast's live input. Venue shows arrive from AIMC capture, the same capture planned for LiveNation.tv.
- **Distribution.** The stream goes to the onestowatch.live player first, then TuneIn, smart speakers and car apps. An ad and measurement vendor can be added later.

The starter kit for the open-source repository and the Softgen build is in the project files at otw-radio/.

Licensing and royalties

Licensing is the longest-lead item and should start first. In the US a non-interactive internet station needs two sets of licenses: one for the songs (compositions) and one for the recordings. Video and on-demand content are not covered by either and need direct permission.

What airs	License needed	Who from	Notes
Released recordings in rotation	Statutory webcasting license for sound recordings	SoundExchange	File a Notice of Use before the first stream. Royalty is per song per listener, roughly $0.003 at current rates (confirm 2026 rate). Annual minimum fee per channel.

What airs	License needed	Who from	Notes
The songs inside those recordings	Public performance licenses	ASCAP, BMI, SESAC and GMR	All four are needed for full coverage. Fees for internet radio are usually a share of revenue with a minimum.
Live shows from venues	Artist consent plus PRO coverage	The artist, under a release in the show offer	Federal anti-bootlegging law requires the performer's consent to transmit a live performance. Add a broadcast addendum to OTW offers.
Video of any music	Sync and master rights	Artist, label and publisher directly	Not covered by the statutory license. Limit video to artist-approved performances and interviews at launch.
Interviews and podcasts	Talent and guest releases	Each guest	On-demand podcast episodes can't carry commercial music without a direct license, so keep podcast versions music-free or use cleared clips.

Three rules of the statutory license shape programming:

1. **Play limits.** In any 3 hours, no more than 3 songs from one album (2 back to back) or 4 by one artist (3 back to back).
2. **No advance song lists.** The station can't publish which songs play when, though it can promote artists and shows.
3. **US listeners only.** The statutory license covers US transmissions. Geo-restrict the stream to the US at launch and license other countries later.

A direct license with an OTW artist and their label waives these limits for that artist and can set a lower or revenue-share royalty. That is the cleanest way to run artist takeovers, replays and video. An alternative for the first year is to stream through a host that bundles US licensing, such as Live365, which trades control for speed.

Staffing

Six people run the station at launch, because automation covers overnight and midday and hosts voice-track their shifts in about an hour each.

Role	FTE	Owns
Station manager and program director	1	The grid, the brand, budget, partner and label relationships
Music director and curator	1	Rotation, adds, play-limit compliance, artist intros
Producer and talent booker	1	Interviews, sessions, podcasts, guest releases
Broadcast engineer and ops	1	Playout, streaming, studio, live ingest from venues and AIMC
Hosts (2 to 3 part-time)	1.5	Morning and afternoon voice tracks, live interview hosting
Social and content producer	0.5	Clips, video cut-downs, socials, show promotion

Add a video producer when video passes about 5 hours a week. Legal and royalty reporting can sit with Live Nation's existing teams or an outside music-rights firm.

Budget

Launch costs about $90K to $160K one-time and $650K to $1M a year to run, with people as the biggest line. Recording royalties come on top and grow with the audience. All figures are planning estimates, not quotes.

One-time

Item	Estimate
Studio: 3 mic positions, mixer, 2 to 3 PTZ cameras, lighting, acoustic treatment	$40K to $70K
Web player and app integration on onestowatch.live	$25K to $40K
Station imaging, jingles and brand package	$10K to $20K
Legal setup: license filings, guest releases, broadcast addendum for offers	$10K to $15K
Playout and streaming setup	$5K to $15K
Total	**$90K to $160K**

Annual

Item	Estimate
Staff, about 6 FTE loaded	$520K to $780K
Launch and ongoing marketing	$50K to $100K
Video streaming and simulcast, event-based	$10K to $40K
Ad insertion and audience measurement	$15K to $30K
Playout software and audio streaming	$10K to $30K
Composition royalties (ASCAP, BMI, SESAC, GMR) at early revenue	$5K to $20K
Remote guest and production tools	about $5K
Total before recording royalties	**$650K to $1M**

Recording royalties (SoundExchange) by audience size

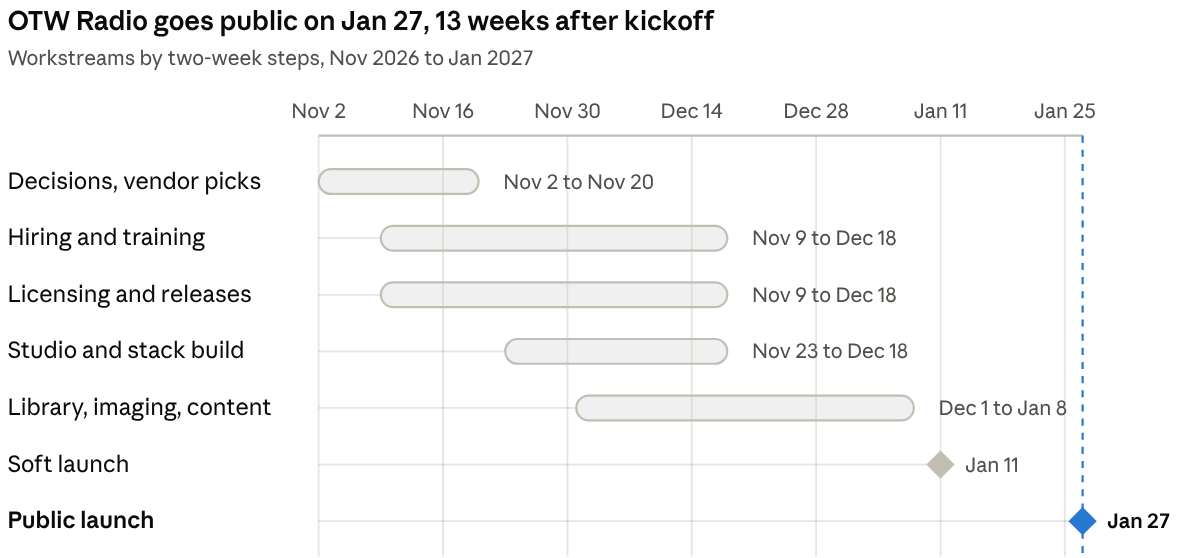
These assume about 10 songs an hour averaged across the day and roughly $0.003 per song per listener.

Average listeners at any moment	Royalty per year
100	about $26K
500	about $130K
1,000	about $260K
5,000	about $1.3M

Every OTW artist on a direct license at a lower rate or a revenue share reduces this line. Revenue from audio ads, sponsors (a presenting sponsor for OTW Live is the obvious first sale) and ticket links is not modeled here.

Launch timeline

Public launch lands on 27 January 2027, the same day the LiveNation.tv Phase 1 paid pilot starts, so OTW Live has venue shows from its first week. Licensing is the critical path: the SoundExchange filing and PRO agreements must be in place before any public stream.



launch timeline · 5 workstreams, 2 milestones

The two weeks around the holidays (21 December to 4 January) are planned as light, which is why content runs to 8 January. The soft launch is an unlisted stream for staff, OTW artists and partners, used to test automation, play-limit compliance and royalty logs. If the decisions slip past 20 November, every later date moves by the same amount.

Open decisions

- [ ] What budget and headcount did the approval cover? The plan above may need trimming or can add a second studio.
- [ ] Which entity holds the licenses: Live Nation, OTW, or a new station entity?
- [ ] US-only at launch (recommended), or license other countries from day one?
- [ ] Ad-supported from launch, or commercial-free with one presenting sponsor for the first months?
- [ ] Which time zone is the grid in, and what should weekends carry? Saturday and Sunday above are proposals.
- [ ] Should live shows ever replay? The LiveNation.tv rule says no unless the artist opts in.
- [ ] What are the formats for Chef's Choice and GWLMMWLG, and who picks each Guest Curator?
- [ ] Who are the hosts: staff, OTW artists rotating as guest hosts, or both?